

Rapido's tech DNA

How open source and AI are powering urban mobility, as per CTO Srivatsa Katta

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“Rapido's tech DNA is built on an open-source, platform-first architecture, run by very lean but highly skilled teams shaped by the cost-disciplined world of bike taxis,” Srivatsa Katta, CTO at Rapido, tells me.

Competing with Ola and Uber, Rapido began life in the most Indian of mobility categories: bike taxis. Not the shiny, VC-slide version of mobility, but still the most practical kind. The category that forces Rapido's product team to reckon with pot-holes and wrong turns. It's also the kind of business that teaches you, very quickly, that you can't brute-force scale with headcount and hope, according to Srivatsa, but you scale with systems.

“Our technological vision has been to become a full-spectrum mobility platform that can serve every type of urban journey on a singular backbone,” says Srivatsa Katta.

“Starting from bike taxis, we built modular, reusable platforms & systems that now power multiple categories and will extend into OTA and multimodal travel,” he says. “This open-source foundation and platform thinking allows us to move fast, stay cost-efficient and respond quickly to new mobility needs as the landscape becomes more competitive.”

It's a very CTO way of saying that we don't want to rebuild the engine every time we add a new vehicle type. And in India's mobility market, where you're constantly compared to Ola and Uber and increasingly to new entrants who show up with flashy UI and aggressive incentives, the bottomline is that the winners are the ones who can keep the machine reliable while expanding categories, cities, and edge cases. Which is where AI – used pragmatically – starts to matter.

Rapido's framing is less “AI as magic” and more as necessary plumbing lines – a multiplier for operational efficiency, decision support, and user experience, without pretending to replace any of the necessary human parts, according to Srivatsa.

“Our focus is on strengthening our platform architecture and scaling our end-to-end mobility vision through expansion into more tier 3 and tier 4 cities alongside urban mobility,” says Katta. “AI will continue to support efficiency in areas like customer support, captain care, airport ride optimization, onboarding automation and multilingual content creation. The broader bet remains open source-heavy, modular platforms that can expand across categories and cities.”

It's a revealing response which tells us how AI is being deployed inside Rapido where it can shave friction –

especially in a country where friction is never just digital. It's linguistic. It's infrastructural. It's behavioural.

Katta is also clear about what AI is not supposed to do: be the final authority in sensitive decisions. “In safety, AI plays a supporting role without making final decisions,” he says. “In sensitive areas like safety and fraud, AI only assists, and human teams make final decisions.” It's an admission from the Rapido CTO that, yes, you can automate a lot but you shouldn't automate accountability.

So it's no surprise that the most tangible example of Rapido's AI work plays out in voice-based order notifications for captains. And the phrase “natural multilingual voices” is doing a lot of work here. India isn't a monolingual market with one default accent, not by a long shot. If Rapido gets that voice right, it's not just a feature. It's a new interface layer – one that points toward Katta's bigger claim about where mobility UX is headed.

“With AI, we are hopeful that the experiences on the app would have a dramatic shift in the next few years, transforming visual experiences to multi-sensory experiences like voice, gestures making it more intuitive and user-friendly,” he says.

Katta does offer a classic moonshot, with a grin you can almost hear in the phrasing. “Maybe drone deliveries, which is really a moonshot idea,” he says. When I ask him what global trend Indian mobility startups might be underestimating, Katta doesn't pick something fashionable or trending like spatial computing or crypto or whatever the internet is yelling wildly about this week. He goes straight for the big one. “Autonomous vehicles and their ability to disrupt the taxi business on Indian roads and infrastructure are a big unknown for Indian mobility startups,” he says. **d**



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